

The All-rounders

While the world debates about convergence, Multi-Functional Devices are already creating a small revolution in the office. A copier-printer-fax-scanner combo spells huge savings not only in terms of money but also cuts the clutter

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You are running your business well only if every resource is fully utilised, and every possible inch of real estate is put to good use. Part of making your business a success, is getting people and components to multi-task. The people we can't help you with, the components we can.

In any office, paper-related devices are widely used. Printers are the most common peripherals; copiers, fax machines and scanners are also popular. Any office will have at least three of these components, and all probably strewn about, wherever space is available. Today, you don't need to settle for multiple devices; instead, you can get a Multi-Functional Device (MFD) that can multi-task.

Choosing the right MFD

The MFD market has evolved to provide multiple verticals that provide a solution for the varied needs. We divided the devices into three categories—Personal, Workgroup and Heavy-duty devices.

The Personal MFDs category contains devices that are sheet-fed and have limited scanning abilities. Most are monochrome scanning devices, and restricted to 256-colour greyscale scanners. Some of these are actually fax machines, with laser printer and scanning capabilities built around them. They are best suited for very low print volumes, as the cost per page is high.

Workgroup MFDs utilise a laser-printing engine. The consumable used is a unified toner cartridge. The toner life is usually rated at 3,000 pages, and a drum is said to last for 7,000 pages. This is in a sealed cartridge, so when your toner is used up, you have to replace the entire cartridge—including the half-used drum.

Heavy-duty MFD technology is the same as copier machines, which are quite rugged. Here, the toner is stored in a separate cartridge from the drum; so you only replace what you use up. Typically, a drum is rated to last for 50,000 pages, and the toner lasts for about 5,000 pages. So, a copier-based MFD actually works out cheaper in the long run.

Personal MFDs

Devices with a smaller footprint are preferred over the huge machines in small offices. Due to the absence of a flatbed scanner, sheet-fed MFDs score



Scanner

A typical stand alone scanner between Rs 5,000 and Rs 15,000



Multi-Functional Device

The prices of MFDs range from Rs 15,000 to Rs 15,00,000, depending upon the features they come with



Fax Machine

A typical fax machine for your office will cost you about Rs 12,000

in terms of space, and do the same job as their bigger counterparts. Here, we looked at three such MFDs from HP, Samsung and Brother. Both the HP and Brother, can print decently, scan, copy and fax, whereas the Samsung is primarily a fax machine that's been souped-up to work as a printer and copier. The Samsung 5100P even comes with a handset—typical of standalone fax machines.

Features

The HP LaserJet 3015 impressed us with its feature list. This MFD is just 426 mm in width, and has an unusual vertical box shape design. All the necessary buttons are on the top—colour scan, copy, fax and print. The USB and Parallel connectors are at the back. The milky white Brother MFC-9660 is just as good looking, but a little larger. It has all the